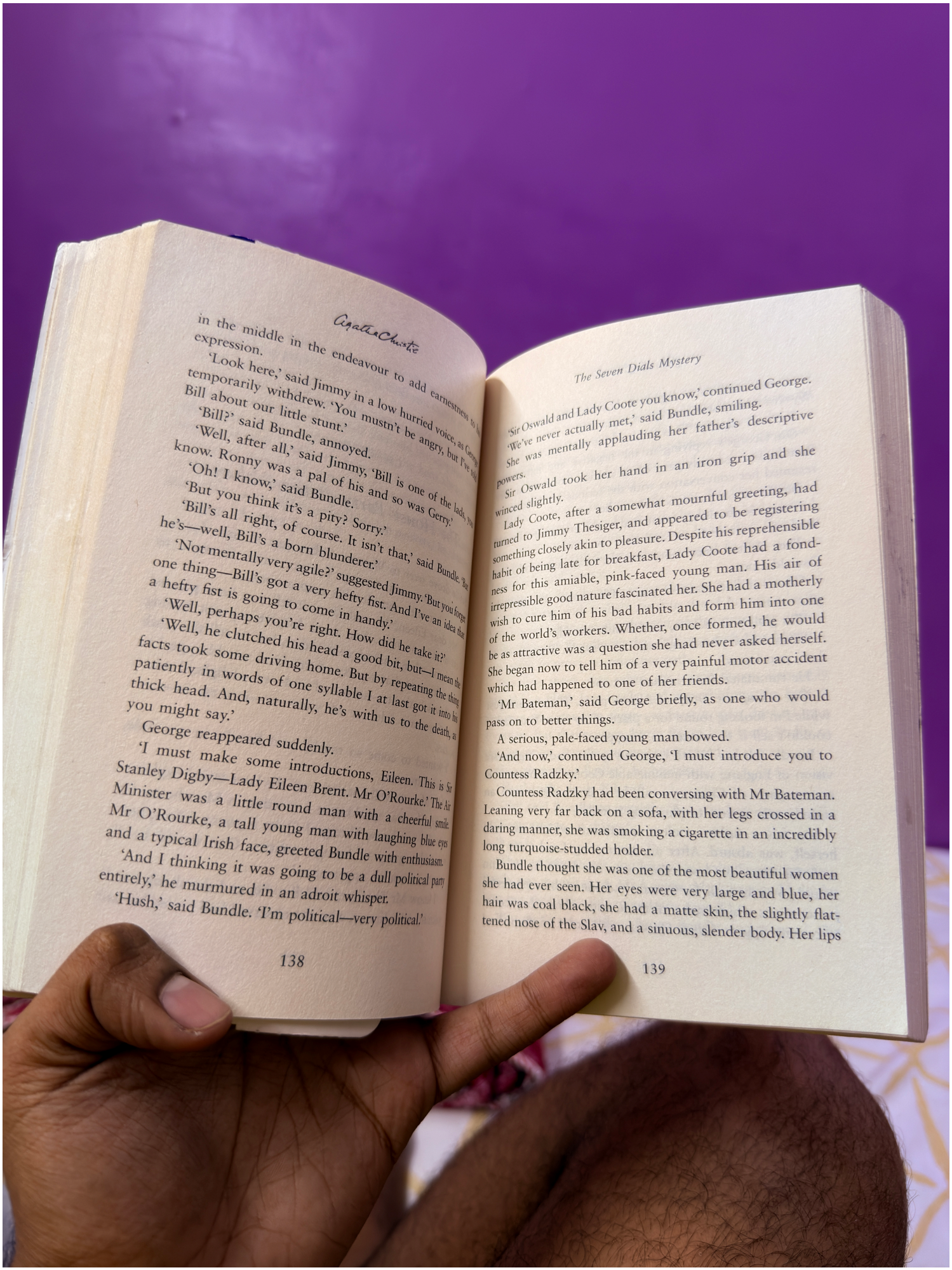

Agatha Christie
in the middle in the endeavour to add earnestness to h
expression.
'Look here,' said Jimmy in a low hurried voice, as Georg
temporarily withdrew. 'You mustn't be angry, but I've told
Bill about our little stunt.'
'Bill?' said Bundle, annoyed.
'Well, after all,' said Jimmy, 'Bill is one of the lads, you
know. Ronny was a pal of his and so was Gerry.'
'Oh! I know,' said Bundle.
'But you think it's a pity? Sorry.'
'That,' said Bundle. 'But
'Bill's all right, of course. It isn't that,
he's—well, Bill's a born blunderer.'
'Not mentally very agile?' suggested Jimmy. 'But you forget
one thing—Bill's got a very hefty fist. And I've an idea that
a hefty fist is going to come in handy.'
'Well, perhaps you're right. How did he take it?'
'Well, he clutched his head a good bit, but—I mean the
facts took some driving home. But by repeating the thing
patiently in words of one syllable I at last got it into his
thick head. And, naturally, he's with us to the death, as
you might say.'
George reappeared suddenly.
'I must make some introductions, Eileen. This is Sir
Stanley Digby—Lady Eileen Brent. Mr O'Rourke.' The Air
Minister was a little round man with a cheerful smile.
Mr O'Rourke, a tall young man with laughing blue eyes
and a typical Irish face, greeted Bundle with enthusiasm.
'And I thinking it was going to be a dull political party
entirely,' he murmured in an adroit whisper.
'Hush,' said Bundle. 'I'm political—very political.'
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'Sir Oswald and Lady Coote you know,' continued George.
'We've never actually met,' said Bundle, smiling.
She was mentally applauding her father's descriptive
powers.
Sir Oswald took her hand in an iron grip and she
winced slightly.
Lady Coote, after a somewhat mournful greeting, had
turned to Jimmy Thesiger, and appeared to be registering
something closely akin to pleasure. Despite his reprehensible
habit of being late for breakfast, Lady Coote had a fond-
ness for this amiable, pink-faced young man. His air of
irrepressible good nature fascinated her. She had a motherly
wish to cure him of his bad habits and form him into one
of the world's workers. Whether, once formed, he would
be as attractive was a question she had never asked herself.
She began now to tell him of a very painful motor accident
which had happened to one of her friends.
'Mr Bateman,' said George briefly, as one who would
pass on to better things.
A serious, pale-faced young man bowed.
'And now,' continued George, 'I must introduce you to
Countess Radzky.'
Countess Radzky had been conversing with Mr Bateman.
Leaning very far back on a sofa, with her legs crossed in a
daring manner, she was smoking a cigarette in an incredibly
long turquoise-studded holder.
Bundle thought she was one of the most beautiful women
she had ever seen. Her eyes were very large and blue, her
hair was coal black, she had a matte skin, the slightly flat-
tened nose of the Slav, and a sinuous, slender body. Her lips
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